PREMIUM COURSE MATERIAL

MODULE 3
LESSON 1

Reference Image Workflow

Learn the essentials of reference image workflow

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LESSON 1: REFERENCE IMAGE WORKFLOW

Once you have your base model from Module 2, every new image you create should be generated using that base as a reference. This is how you maintain consistency across hundreds of images. The reference image workflow is the backbone of your content pipeline. Without it, every image looks like a different person and your page screams fake.

Both Seedream 4.5 and Nano Banana 2 support reference-based generation. You upload your seed image, write a prompt describing the new scene, and the tool generates output that preserves your character's face while creating the new content. This lesson covers how to use this workflow effectively.

The Reference Workflow

- → Start with your locked-in seed image from Module 2
- → Upload it as a reference/input image in Seedream 4.5 or Nano Banana 2
- → Write a new prompt describing the desired scene, outfit, or setting
- → Generate multiple outputs (3-5 per prompt) and compare against the reference
- → Only keep images that match the face consistently
- → If the face drifts, increase reference strength or try a different seed angle

Choosing the Right Tool for Each Shot

Seedream 4.5 and Nano Banana 2 have different strengths. Knowing when to use each one saves time and produces better results.

- Seedream 4.5 — Best for close-up portraits, headshots, and detailed facial expressions. Strongest at preserving fine facial details
- Nano Banana 2 — Best for full-body shots, varied poses, and lifestyle scenes with complex backgrounds
- For critical content (profile photos, first grid posts), generate with both tools and compare
- For daily content, use whichever tool handles that content type best

Reference Image Best Practices

- Use a clear, front-facing headshot as your primary reference
- Keep 2-3 reference angles saved (front, 3/4 turn, profile) for variety
- Higher resolution reference images produce better consistency
- Never change your reference image once your page is live
- When switching between Seedream and Nano Banana, use the same reference image

> **IMAGE PLACEHOLDER**
>
> Step-by-step visual of the reference workflow: 1. Upload seed image → 2. Write new prompt → 3. Generate variations → 4. Compare to reference → 5. Keep or regenerate. Show example reference image producing 3-4 different outputs.

Common Mistakes in Reference Workflow

- Using a low-quality or small reference image — always use full resolution
- Setting reference strength too low — face drifts from your model
- Setting reference strength too high — every image looks identical (no variety)
- Ignoring face drift on 'almost good enough' images — never post a drifted face
- Changing reference images between sessions — stick with the same seed

> **IMAGE PLACEHOLDER**
>
> Example showing reference image → 3-4 different output images generated from it, with annotations showing face consistency maintained across different settings and outfits

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END SUMMARY

- Always generate new images using your base model as a reference in Seedream 4.5 or Nano Banana 2
- Write detailed prompts with setting, lighting, outfit, and camera angle — save templates that produce good results
- Use Seedream 4.5 for portraits and close-ups, Nano Banana 2 for full-body and lifestyle shots
- Edit AI outputs to fix hands, artifacts, and background issues using Photopea (free)
- Always add approximately 2% grain/noise as the final editing step — this is what makes AI images pass as real photos
- Use inpainting to fix specific problem areas without regenerating the entire image
- Know each platform's content rules — TikTok and Instagram are strictest, Reddit is most flexible
- When in doubt, keep it safe — a content strike can derail weeks of progress

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